Justifications of Dyadic Harm in Political Manifestos

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The theory of dyadic morality suggests that judgments of harm give moral valence to relationships between an intentional agent and vulnerable patient (Schein & Gray, 2018). That is, dyadic morality predicts that if one were to see someone (i.e., an agent) intentionally harming another person (i.e., a vulnerable patient), one would judge that this action (i.e., the harming of another person) is immoral or morally wrong. Furthermore, social interactions are composed of moral norms as mutually agreed upon rules as to how citizens ought to behave. Although moral norms (e.g., do not murder) are meant to keep people from damaging others, some justify norm violations — and harm — in pursuit of a goal (e.g., political assassinations), whereas others never condone violence to induce change. Understanding what differentiates violent and non-violent agents is therefore useful in protecting against harmful acts. One source that marks such differences is the political manifesto (i.e., "a written statement declaring publicly the intentions, motives, or views of its issuer"; Merriam-Webster, n.d.). The current study targets differences in linguistic indicators of justifications of harm and integrative complexity between violence-condoning and non-violent manifestos.

Research on linguistic markers of political violence follows the growing number of far-right manifestos published online prior to terrorist attacks (Capelos, DaVisio, & Salmela, 2025; Ebner, Kavanagh, & Whitehouse, 2025). Some of these studies evaluate manifestos through the fusion-plus-threat model of violent extremism (Whitehouse, 2018), which predicts that individuals who lump their personal and group identities together will be more likely to self-sacrifice for their group. Associated linguistic work suggests that words indicating identity fusion, group threat, and violence-condoning norms — including justifications of violence — are correlated with terrorism (Ebner, Kavanagh, & Whitehouse, 2024; Ebner et al., 2025). While the existing literature grounds the importance of justificatory rhetoric in predicting terrorism, harm has not yet been examined as central to moral judgment despite its importance in some theories of moral

judgment (e.g., the theory of dyadic morality). The present study serves as a real-world case on how emotion and reason interact to produce the judgments and justifications necessary for enacting harm. Connecting the political manifesto and moral judgment literatures will enlighten respective research as to (a) how moral reasoning implicates justification in manifestos and (b) how justification operates in the moral reasoning process, each of which could have policy implications.

Integrative Complexity is a linguistic measure of cognitive complexity composed of two primary components: (a) Differentiation and (b) Integration (Suedfeld, Tetlock, & Streufert, 1992). Differentiation indicates how many perspectives one accounts for; Integration indicates the extent to which those differentiated perspectives are synthesized. A useful example is an argumentative essay, which, if it is complex, recognizes a variety of possible arguments for or against some claim, and synthesizes those arguments into one ultimate argument, using parts of each subsidiary argument (Ballesteros, 2025). Integrative complexity shows a robust relationship with political violence (Suedfeld, 2010). However, research using the construct as a predictor of political violence has largely focused on political leaders in respect to events like war and international crises (Suedfeld, 2010). To my knowledge, no study to date has directly linked the integrative complexity of political manifestos with justifications of political violence. Considering the measure's long-standing precedent in predicting political events, integrating integrative complexity into the manifesto literature could help identify the factors that distinguish between merely violent rhetoric and rhetoric that induces violence, thereby affording greater predictability through an aggregation of said factors.

Current Study

The current study contributes to research seeking to identify differences between violent and non-violent political agents through an evaluation of political manifestos in two new ways: (a) by focusing a qualitative analysis on rhetoric about harm as designating

moral valence by the theory of dyadic morality and (b) by scoring manifestos on integrative complexity. I seek to aid in answering three related questions: (a) do justifications of harm correspond to changes in individual moral norms?; (b) does integrative complexity predict whether a manifesto will result in violence versus non-violence?; and (c) does integrative complexity predict both temporally near and far instances of violence in relation to political manifestos? I predict that (a) changes in moral norms — as exemplified in the agents' writings — and subsequent justification of increasingly harmful acts will be associated with a higher likelihood of violence, (b) lower levels of integrative complexity in political manifestos will predict higher likelihoods of violence, and (c) a decrease in integrative complexity will be associated with an individual coming to believe that harm is justified in pursuit of their political goals.

Method

Manifesto Selection

This study includes manifestos divided into three categories following Ebner et al. (2025); (a) violent self-sacrificial, (b) ideologically extreme, and (c) moderate. It also affords longitudinal analysis. I selected not only one-off manifestos already analyzed in the aforementioned literature (e.g., Anders Behring Breivik's Manifesto of the Norway Attacks, 2011; Marx & Engels Manifesto of the Communist Party, 1848), but also sets of writings of individual authors across time (e.g., selections of Vladimir Lenin's letters). Materials include ten manifestos for each of the aforementioned categories, and three longitudinal sets of writings for each category. Incorporating the 15 manifestos previously analyzed in the literature brings the study to a categorical count as follows: (a) nine violent self-sacrificial texts, (b) three ideologically extreme texts, and (c) 3 moderate texts. Each of these texts are one-off samples. To fill out the rest of the ten one-off samples for each category, manifestos were selected according to their place on the political spectrum (i.e.,

left to right political platforms), individual actor-author texts versus platform-representative texts, and length in order to match each category along these factors. The same factors were considered in choosing longitudinal samples, and selection included qualitatively matching samples across categories.

Measures

Linguistic Indicators. Ebner et al. (2025) supplies a list of words that indicate justifications of violence and, as a higher-order category of linguistic markers, violence condoning norms. The current study uses the set of words indicating violence condoning norms with minor alterations. First, indicators like "need for jihaad" (Ebner et al., 2025) have been replaced with relevant phrasing (e.g., need for war; need for revolution). Second, specific indicators of talk about harm in dyadic morality (e.g., harm, damage, agent, patient, intentional) have been added to the list of indicators.

Automated Integrative Complexity. Hand-scoring integrative complexity is an involved process requiring multiple scorers and often hours of work per scored material. In light of time and manpower limitations, this study instead uses automated integrative complexity (Conway, Conway, Gornick, & Houck, 2014) to score materials, a measure that uses linguistic markers of differentiation and integration to construct an automated account of integrative complexity. While automated integrative complexity does not correlate perfectly with hand scores (document-level correlation of .82, paragraph-level correlation of .46, Conway, Conway, & Houck, 2020), it is an increasingly validated measure in its own right and often used as an efficient and effective replacement for hand scoring. This study uses the document-level scores for all analyses.

Violence. Previously analyzed manifestos are easily delineated as to whether they cause violence; some manifestos precede lone-actor attacks by their author, the other manifestos did not precede violence enacted by their author. The present study maintains this distinction. However, it also includes platform-based violence by identifying

institutional violence in direct causal relationship with the philosophies put forward by corresponding manifestos. For example, a manifesto by a political leader that accompanies a war (e.g., the *Russian Imperial Manifesto of 1914* by Tzar Nicholas II announcing Russia's entry into World War One; Golder, 1927) would be counted as violent; a manifesto espoused by a political leader that does not accompany institutional violence by that leader's institution (e.g., John F. Kennedy's *Ich bin ein Berliner*) would be counted as non-violent.

Analyses. Following Ebner et al. (2024), I measure the prevalence of each linguistic marker group as occurrences per 1,000 words (word-count–normalized rates). Marker groups include dyadic harm language (added to reflect dyadic morality), justification for violence, martyrdom narratives, hopelessness of alternatives, role model status, and violent references.

To test whether these linguistic indicators differ across manifesto categories (moderate, ideologically extreme, violent self-sacrificial), I estimate linear models predicting each marker group's prevalence from category and report category means with confidence intervals.

To directly test the hypothesis that integrative complexity predicts violence versus non-violence, I estimate logistic regression models predicting whether a manifesto is classified as violent (vs. non-violent) from document-level AutoIC integrative complexity scores (and, in expanded models, from the marker-group prevalence measures).

For longitudinal corpora (multiple texts per author over time), I estimate mixed-effects regression models assessing (a) within-author changes in integrative complexity and harm-justification language over time and (b) whether lower integrative complexity is associated with higher harm-justification language within authors. Where violence event dates are available, I additionally examine whether integrative complexity and harm-justification indicators differ in texts written nearer versus farther from the

violence event.

Results

```r
cat("doc_scores_all rows:", nrow(doc_scores_all), "\n")
```

```
## doc_scores_all rows: 292
```

```r
cat("Unique corpus values:\n")
```

```
## Unique corpus values:
```

```r
print(table(doc_scores_all$corpus, useNA = "ifany"))
```

```
##
##     longitudinal non_longitudinal
##              221               71
```

```r
cat("\nRows by corpus x has_ic:\n")
```

```
##
## Rows by corpus x has_ic:
```

```r
print(
  doc_scores_all |>
    dplyr::mutate(has_ic = !is.na(ic)) |>
    dplyr::count(corpus, has_ic)
)
```

```
## # A tibble: 4 x 3
##   corpus           has_ic     n
##   <chr>            <lgl>  <int>
## 1 longitudinal     FALSE     27
## 2 longitudinal     TRUE     194
## 3 non_longitudinal FALSE     41
## 4 non_longitudinal TRUE      30
```

```r
cat("\nExample longitudinal rows:\n")
```

```
##
## Example longitudinal rows:
```

```r
print(
  doc_scores_all |>
    dplyr::filter(stringr::str_detect(tolower(corpus), "long")) |>
    dplyr::select(doc_id, corpus, author, ic) |>
    head(30)
)
```

```
## # A tibble: 30 x 4
##    doc_id                                                    corpus author    ic
##    <chr>                                                     <chr>  <chr>  <dbl>
##  1 1160kennedyichbin                                         non_l~ <NA>    2.08
##  2 142thunberg                                               non_l~ <NA>    2.14
##  3 1945labourpartymanifesto                                  non_l~ <NA>    2.01
##  4 1949simonedebeauvoirthesecondsex                          non_l~ <NA>    5.37
##  5 acontributiontothehistoryofthenationalprogrammeinaustria~ longi~ lenin   2.22
```

```
## 6 adisgracefulresolution10181912                          longi~ lenin   2.38
## 7 ahouseofmanymansions1940                                longi~ churc~  1.87
## 8 ahushovereurope1939                                     longi~ churc~  1.72
## 9 anewchapterofworldhistory10211912                       longi~ lenin   2.81
## 10 addresstojointsessionofuscongress1941                  longi~ churc~  1.84
## # i 20 more rows
```

```r
cat("=== AutoIC join coverage (right after merge-autoic) ===\n")
```

```
## === AutoIC join coverage (right after merge-autoic) ===
```

```r
doc_scores |>
  dplyr::summarise(
    n_total = dplyr::n(),
    n_with_ic = sum(!is.na(ic)),
    n_missing_ic = sum(is.na(ic))
  ) |>
  print()
```

```
## # A tibble: 1 x 3
##   n_total n_with_ic n_missing_ic
##     <int>     <int>        <int>
## 1      27        27            0
```

```r
cat("\nBy corpus:\n")
```

```
##
## By corpus:
```

```r
doc_scores |>
  dplyr::group_by(corpus) |>
  dplyr::summarise(
    n_total = dplyr::n(),
    n_with_ic = sum(!is.na(ic)),
    n_missing_ic = sum(is.na(ic)),
    .groups = "drop"
  ) |>
  print()
```

```
## # A tibble: 1 x 4
##   corpus           n_total n_with_ic n_missing_ic
##   <chr>              <int>     <int>        <int>
## 1 non_longitudinal      27        27            0
```

```r
cat("\nCorpus levels comparison:\n")
```

```
##
## Corpus levels comparison:
```

```r
print(sort(unique(doc_scores$corpus)))
```

```
## [1] "non_longitudinal"
```

```r
print(sort(unique(autoic_doc$corpus)))
```

```
## [1] "longitudinal"     "non_longitudinal"
```

```r
cat("\nKey overlap checks:\n")
```

```
##
## Key overlap checks:
```

```r
doc_keys <- doc_scores |> dplyr::distinct(doc_id, corpus)
autoic_keys <- autoic_doc |> dplyr::distinct(doc_id, corpus)

cat("Matches on doc_id only:",
    sum(unique(doc_scores$doc_id) %in% unique(autoic_doc$doc_id)),
    "of", dplyr::n_distinct(doc_scores$doc_id), "\n")
```

```
## Matches on doc_id only: 27 of 27
```

```r
cat("Matches on (doc_id, corpus):",
    nrow(dplyr::inner_join(doc_keys, autoic_keys, by = c("doc_id", "corpus"))),
    "of", nrow(doc_keys), "\n")
```

```
## Matches on (doc_id, corpus): 27 of 27
```

```r
cat("\nExample doc_scores keys not found in autoic_doc (first 20):\n")
```

```
##
## Example doc_scores keys not found in autoic_doc (first 20):
```

```r
doc_keys |>
  dplyr::anti_join(autoic_keys, by = c("doc_id", "corpus")) |>
  head(20) |>
  print()
```

```
## # A tibble: 0 x 2
## # i 2 variables: doc_id <chr>, corpus <chr>
```

```r
cat("\nExample autoic_doc keys not found in doc_scores (first 20):\n")
```

```
##
## Example autoic_doc keys not found in doc_scores (first 20):
```

```r
autoic_keys |>
  dplyr::anti_join(doc_keys, by = c("doc_id", "corpus")) |>
  head(20) |>
  print()
```

```
## # A tibble: 20 x 2
##    doc_id                                                                  corpus
##    <chr>                                                                   <chr>
##  1 acontributiontothehistoryofthenationalprogrammeinaustriaandinrussia25~ longi~
##  2 addresstojointsessionofuscongress1941                                   longi~
##  3 adisgracefulresolution10181912                                          longi~
##  4 afantasy19991999                                                        longi~
##  5 againstpessimism4151924                                                 longi~
##  6 ahouseofmanymansions1940                                                longi~
##  7 ahushovereurope1939                                                     longi~
##  8 americancivilization1945                                                longi~
##  9 andersbreivik2083manifesto2011pdfbookone                                non_l~
## 10 anewchapterofworldhistory10211912                                       longi~
## 11 apologytowomen1996                                                      longi~
## 12 ascientificamericanarticletheorizingatechinducedapocalypsetheunabombe~ longi~
```

```
## 13 ashifttowardshopefulness1996                                          longi~
## 14 beyemenofvalour1940                                                   longi~
## 15 billontheequalityofnationsandthesafeguardingoftherightsofnationalmino~ longi~
## 16 bloodtoiltearsandsweat1940                                            longi~
## 17 bolshevismandimperialsedition1920                                     longi~
## 18 cadetsandnationalists10241912                                         longi~
## 19 cadetsonthequestionoftheukraine7161913                                longi~
## 20 character331917                                                       longi~
```

Descriptive Statistics

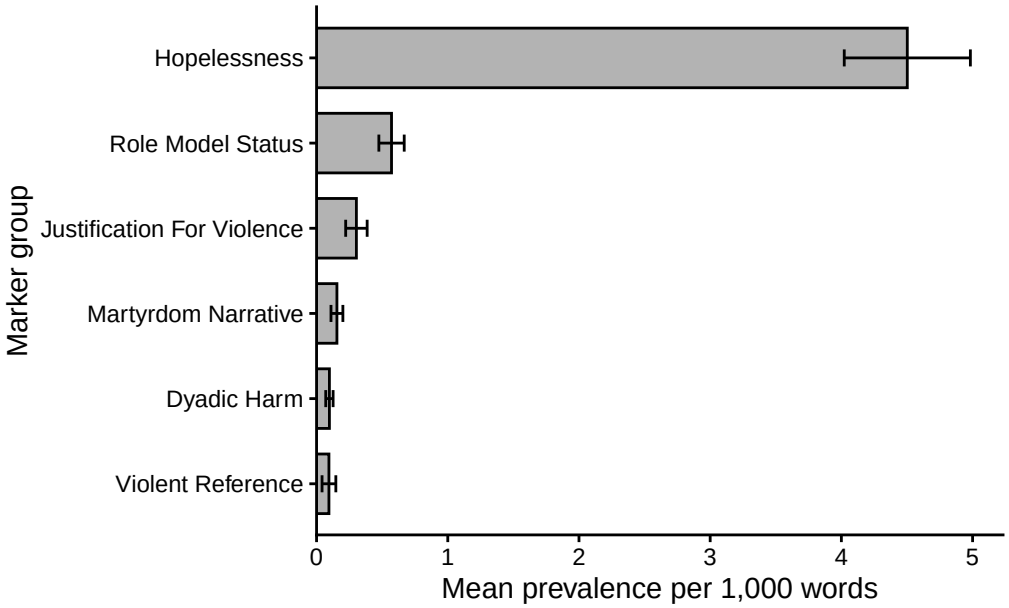

Figure 1. Mean prevalence of grouped linguistic indicators of harm justification. Note. Bars represent mean grouped marker prevalence per 1,000 words across documents. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Marker groups aggregate lexical indicators defined in the study's marker dictionary.

Descriptive statistics were calculated to examine the prevalence of grouped linguistic indicators of harm justification across the manifesto corpus. Prevalence values represent

occurrences of grouped markers per 1,000 words. Across all 251 manifestos, markers associated with hopelessness were the most common (M = 4.50, SD = 4.19), followed by role model status (M = 0.57, SD = 0.84), justification for violence (M = 0.30, SD = 0.71), martyrdom narratives (M = 0.16, SD = 0.40), dyadic harm language (M = 0.10, SD = 0.24), and references to violent actors or events (M = 0.09, SD = 0.46). Minimum and maximum prevalence values ranged from 0 to 26.32 depending on marker group.

Mean marker prevalence also differed across manifesto categories (Table 1). Violent self-sacrificial manifestos exhibited the highest average prevalence of dyadic harm language (M = 0.18) and justification for violence (M =), whereas moderate manifestos displayed very low levels of these indicators (dyadic harm M = 0.01; justification for violence M =). Martyrdom narratives showed the most pronounced difference across categories, appearing most frequently in violent manifestos (M = 0.56) compared with extreme (M = 0.16) and moderate texts (M = 0.08). In contrast, markers associated with hopelessness were most prevalent in ideologically extreme manifestos (M = 5.17), followed by moderate manifestos (M = 3.45) and violent manifestos (M = 2.30).

Table 1

Mean prevalence of grouped linguistic indicators by manifesto category.

Marker Group	moderate	extreme	violent
Dyadic Harm	0.01	0.18	0.18
Justification for Violence	0.16	0.18	0.47
Martyrdom Narrative	0.08	0.16	0.56
Hopelessness	3.45	5.17	2.30

Note. Values represent grouped marker prevalence per 1,000 words.

Regression Analyses

To examine whether manifesto category predicts the prevalence of harm-related linguistic indicators, a series of linear regression models were estimated. Each model predicted the prevalence of a marker group from manifesto category, with moderate manifestos serving as the reference category.

Dyadic Harm Language. The regression model predicting dyadic harm language indicated that manifesto category was marginally associated with variation in dyadic harm prevalence, $F(2, 28) = 3.10$, $p = .061$, $R^2 = .18$. Compared with moderate manifestos, ideologically extreme manifestos contained significantly higher levels of dyadic harm language ($b = 0.16$, SE = 0.08, $t = 2.16$, $p = .040$). Violent self-sacrificial manifestos also showed significantly higher prevalence of dyadic harm markers relative to moderate texts ($b = 0.18$, SE = 0.08, $t = 2.21$, $p = .035$).

Table 2

Logistic regression predicting violent (vs. non-violent) manifesto category from integrative complexity and linguistic indicators.

Predictor	OR	CI	p
Integrative Complexity (z)	0.04	[0, 0.69]	0.050
Dyadic Harm (z)	1.95	[0.7, 8.4]	0.246
Justification for Violence (z)	4.05	[0.93, 27.5]	0.084
Martyrdom Narrative (z)	14.63	[1.42, 612.63]	0.060
Hopelessness (z)	0.57	[0.05, 3.67]	0.579

Note. Odds ratios (OR) reflect 1 SD increases in standardized predictors.

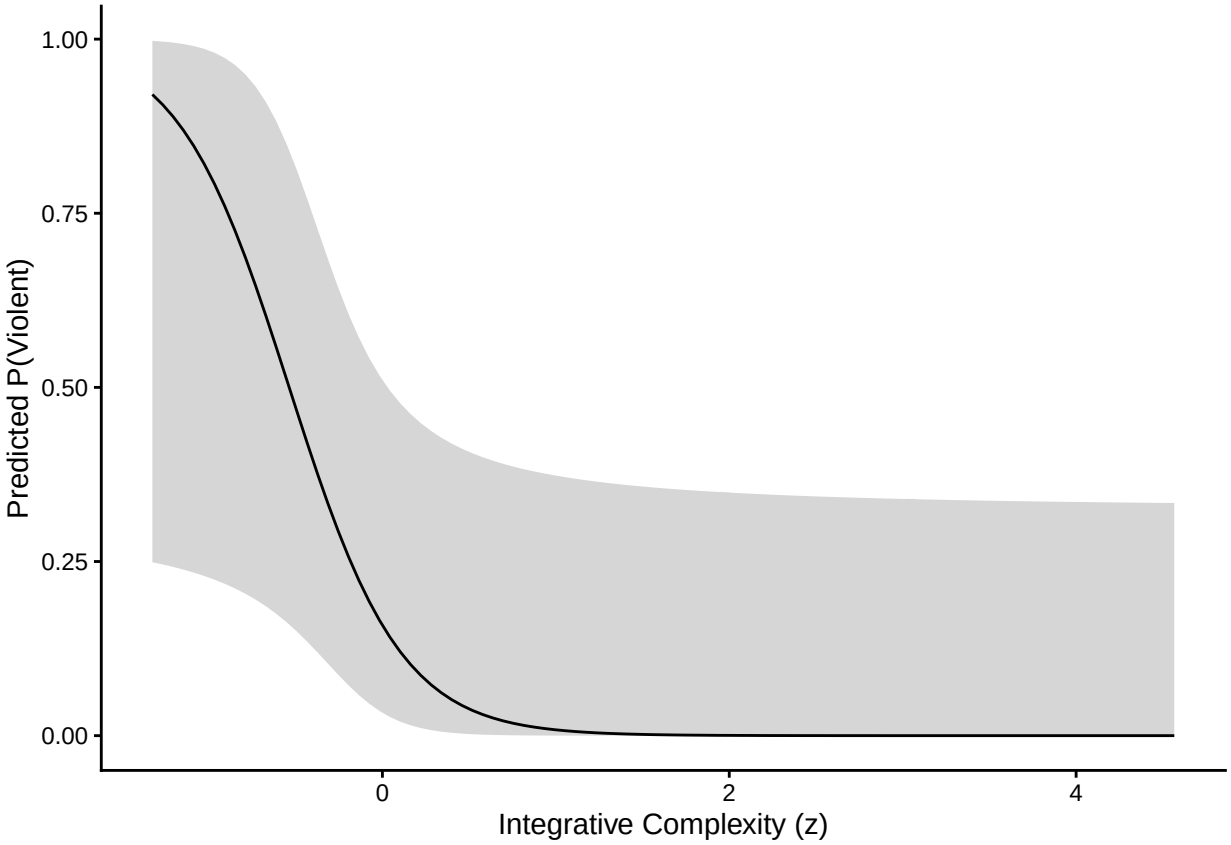

Figure 2. Predicted probability of violent (vs. non-violent) category as a function of integrative complexity (95% CI).

Integrative Complexity Predicting Violence.

Justifications for Violence. The regression model predicting justifications for violence was not statistically significant overall, $F(2, 28) = 1.88$, $p = .171$, $R^2 = .12$. Neither ideologically extreme manifestos ($b = 0.05$, SE $= 0.16$, $t = 0.33$, $p = .744$) nor violent manifestos ($b = 0.30$, SE $= 0.17$, $t = 1.78$, $p = .085$) differed significantly from moderate manifestos in their prevalence of justification language. However, the coefficient for violent manifestos approached conventional levels of statistical significance, suggesting a potential trend toward greater justificatory rhetoric in manifestos associated with violence.

Martyrdom Narratives. The regression model predicting martyrdom narratives was statistically significant, $F(2, 28) = 3.94$, $p = .031$, $R^2 = .22$. Violent self-sacrificial

Table 3

Linear regression coefficients predicting grouped marker prevalence from manifesto category.

Outcome	Contrast	B	SE	t	p
Dyadic Harm	Extreme vs. Moderate	0.17	0.08	1.97	0.061
Dyadic Harm	Violent vs. Moderate	0.16	0.09	1.82	0.081
Justification	Extreme vs. Moderate	0.02	0.18	0.14	0.893
Justification	Violent vs. Moderate	0.32	0.18	1.71	0.100
Martyrdom	Extreme vs. Moderate	0.07	0.20	0.38	0.711
Martyrdom	Violent vs. Moderate	0.47	0.21	2.27	0.032
Hopelessness	Extreme vs. Moderate	1.72	1.22	1.41	0.172
Hopelessness	Violent vs. Moderate	-1.16	1.29	-0.90	0.379

Note. Moderate manifestos served as the reference category.

manifestos exhibited significantly higher levels of martyrdom narrative markers compared with moderate texts (b = 0.47, SE = 0.19, t = 2.50, p = .019). In contrast, ideologically extreme manifestos did not differ significantly from moderate manifestos in martyrdom language (b = 0.05, SE = 0.17, t = 0.28, p = .780).

Hopelessness. The regression model predicting hopelessness markers was not statistically significant overall, F(2, 28) = 2.48, p = .102, R^2 = .15. Neither ideologically extreme manifestos (b = 1.75, SE = 1.25, t = 1.41, p = .171) nor violent manifestos (b = -0.93, SE = 1.36, t = -0.69, p = .497) differed significantly from moderate manifestos in the prevalence of hopelessness language.

Summary of Findings. Across models, manifesto category predicted significant differences in two linguistic domains: dyadic harm language and martyrdom narratives. Both ideologically extreme and violent manifestos contained higher levels of dyadic harm

Table 4

Linear regression coefficients predicting document-level autoIC outcomes from linguistic indicators and manifesto category.

Outcome	Predictor	B	SE	t	p
IC	Justification for Violence	0.12	0.40	0.30	0.768
IC	Dyadic Harm	0.50	0.82	0.61	0.551
IC	Extreme vs. Moderate	-0.14	0.37	-0.37	0.713
IC	Violent vs. Moderate	-0.56	0.41	-1.36	0.187
Dial	Justification for Violence	0.07	0.32	0.23	0.817
Dial	Dyadic Harm	0.43	0.65	0.67	0.509
Dial	Extreme vs. Moderate	-0.04	0.29	-0.16	0.878
Dial	Violent vs. Moderate	-0.30	0.32	-0.94	0.358
Elab	Justification for Violence	0.10	0.32	0.33	0.748
Elab	Dyadic Harm	0.39	0.66	0.60	0.557
Elab	Extreme vs. Moderate	-0.29	0.30	-0.97	0.341
Elab	Violent vs. Moderate	-0.48	0.33	-1.45	0.162
IC Differentiation	Justification for Violence	0.12	0.18	0.65	0.523
IC Differentiation	Dyadic Harm	0.40	0.37	1.08	0.290
IC Differentiation	Extreme vs. Moderate	0.02	0.16	0.14	0.889
IC Differentiation	Violent vs. Moderate	-0.24	0.18	-1.30	0.207
IC Integration	Justification for Violence	0.00	0.25	0.02	0.988
IC Integration	Dyadic Harm	0.10	0.50	0.20	0.844
IC Integration	Extreme vs. Moderate	-0.16	0.23	-0.72	0.482
IC Integration	Violent vs. Moderate	-0.32	0.25	-1.27	0.217
Dial Differentiation	Justification for Violence	0.08	0.20	0.38	0.709
Dial Differentiation	Dyadic Harm	0.35	0.42	0.84	0.408
Dial Differentiation	Extreme vs. Moderate	0.06	0.19	0.33	0.748
Dial Differentiation	Violent vs. Moderate	-0.13	0.21	-0.62	0.541
Dial Integration	Justification for Violence	-0.01	0.13	-0.07	0.947
Dial Integration	Dyadic Harm	0.09	0.26	0.35	0.728

language relative to moderate texts, suggesting that framing political issues in terms of intentional harm and victimization may be characteristic of more radical ideological writing. Additionally, violent self-sacrificial manifestos displayed significantly greater use of martyrdom narratives than moderate texts, indicating that rhetorical appeals to sacrifice and heroism may play an important role in texts associated with political violence.

Longitudinal Analyses

```
## # A tibble: 194 x 3
##    author    doc_id                                                  doc_date
##    <chr>     <chr>                                                   <date>
##  1 churchill bolshevismandimperialsedition1920                       1920-01-01
##  2 churchill masseffectsinmodernlife1925                             1925-01-01
##  3 churchill fiftyyearshence1931                                     1931-01-01
##  4 churchill pennyintheslotpolitics1934                              1934-01-01
##  5 churchill ihavewatchedthisfamousisland1938                        1938-01-01
##  6 churchill thelightsaregoingoutwemustarm1938                       1938-01-01
##  7 churchill ahushovereurope1939                                     1939-01-01
##  8 churchill warspeech1939                                           1939-01-01
##  9 churchill ahouseofmanymansions1940                                1940-01-01
## 10 churchill beyemenofvalour1940                                     1940-01-01
## 11 churchill bloodtoiltearsandsweat1940                              1940-01-01
## 12 churchill everymantohispost1940                                   1940-01-01
## 13 churchill thefew1940                                              1940-01-01
## 14 churchill theirfinesthour1940                                     1940-01-01
## 15 churchill waroftheunknownwarriors1940                             1940-01-01
## 16 churchill weshallfightonthebeaches1940                            1940-01-01
## 17 churchill addresstojointsessionofuscongress1941                   1941-01-01
```

```
## 18 churchill doyourworstwelldoourbest1941                          1941-01-01
## 19 churchill giveusthetools1941                                    1941-01-01
## 20 churchill nevergiveinnevernevernever1941                        1941-01-01
## 21 churchill somechickensomeneck1941                               1941-01-01
## 22 churchill thefourthclimacteric1941                              1941-01-01
## 23 churchill theoldlion1941                                        1941-01-01
## 24 churchill winstonchurchillsbroadcastonthesovietgermanwar1941    1941-01-01
## 25 churchill theinvasionoffrance1944                               1944-01-01
## 26 churchill thesinewsofpeace1946                                  1946-01-01
## 27 churchill mitmidcenturyconvocation1949                          1949-01-01
## 28 churchill thecouncilofeurope1949                                1949-01-01
## 29 evola     decadence1928                                         1928-01-01
## 30 evola     fascism1928                                           1928-01-01
## 31 evola     darkage1934                                           1934-01-01
## 32 evola     jihad1934                                             1934-01-01
## 33 evola     degeneration1938                                      1938-01-01
## 34 evola     neopagans1942                                         1942-01-01
## 35 evola     americancivilization1945                              1945-01-01
## 36 evola     occult1953                                            1953-01-01
## 37 gramsci   theeventsof23december19191261319                      1319-01-01
## 38 gramsci   newspapersandtheworkers12221916                        1916-12-22
## 39 gramsci   menormachines12241916                                  1916-12-24
## 40 gramsci   character331917                                        1917-03-03
## 41 gramsci   therevolutionagainstcapital12241917                    1917-12-24
## 42 gramsci   oneyearofhistory3161918                                1918-03-16
## 43 gramsci   redink441919                                           1919-04-04
## 44 gramsci   thepriceofhistory671919                                1919-06-07
```

```
## 45 gramsci   workersdemocracy6211919                                  1919-06-21
## 46 gramsci   theconquestofthestate7121919                             1919-07-12
## 47 gramsci   workersandpeasants821919                                 1919-08-02
## 48 gramsci   tothesectioncommissarsofthefiatbrevettiworkshops9131919 1919-09-13
## 49 gramsci   chroniclesofthenewordер9131919                          1919-09-13
## 50 gramsci   thedevelopmentoftherevolution9131919                     1919-09-13
## # i 144 more rows
```

```
## Longitudinal analysis rows: 194
```

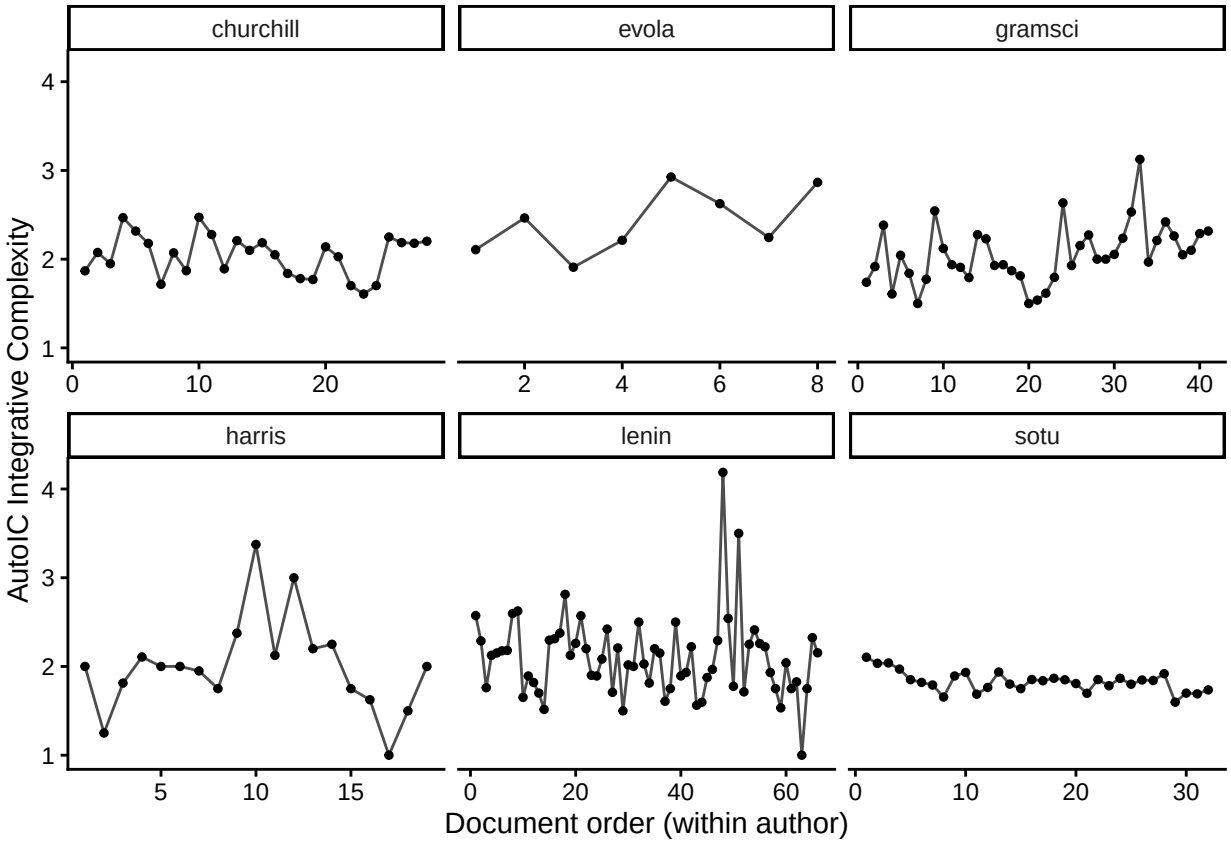

Figure 3. Longitudinal trajectories of integrative complexity by author (document order).

Table 5

Longitudinal mixed-effects models testing within-author change and the association between integrative complexity and justification language.

Model	Term	B	SE	t
Justification ~ IC + Time	ic	-0.12	0.12	-1.02
Justification ~ IC + Time	time_c	0.00	0.00	0.78
IC ~ Time	time_c	0.00	0.00	0.16

Note. Models include random intercepts and random slopes for time by author (lme4::lmer).

Table 6

Within-author temporal proximity models for the violent longitudinal case (Harris).

Outcome	B_days	SE_days	p_days
IC	0.00	0.00	0.637
Justification for Violence	0.00	0.00	NaN

Note. Predictor is days remaining until the violence event date; positive B indicates higher outcome farther from the event.

Discussion

The present study examined whether linguistic indicators associated with moral justifications of harm differ systematically across political manifesto types. Specifically, the analysis tested whether grouped linguistic markers related to dyadic harm framing, justification for violence, martyrdom narratives, and expressions of political hopelessness vary across moderate, ideologically extreme, and violent self-sacrificial manifestos. These analyses represent an initial empirical step toward evaluating the broader hypothesis that linguistic indicators of harm justification correspond to an increased likelihood of political violence.

The results provide partial support for the proposed theoretical framework. Manifestos categorized as ideologically extreme and violent self-sacrificial exhibited significantly higher levels of dyadic harm language compared with moderate manifestos. In other words, texts associated with more radical ideological positions more frequently framed political conflict in terms of identifiable agents causing harm to identifiable victims.

This pattern aligns with research in moral psychology emphasizing the centrality of harm perception in moral judgment. In particular, the theory of dyadic morality proposes that moral cognition is structured around a perceived relationship between a moral agent who causes harm and a moral patient who suffers it. According to this framework, moral judgments frequently emerge from narratives that identify perpetrators, victims, and causal responsibility. The elevated prevalence of dyadic harm language in extreme and violent manifestos suggests that such texts more frequently construct political grievances in explicitly moralized terms, portraying social or political conflict as situations in which identifiable actors harm identifiable victims.

However, the remaining linguistic indicators examined in this study (i.e., justifications for violence, martyrdom narratives, and expressions of political hopelessness) did not differ significantly across manifesto categories. Although these markers were intended to capture rhetorical patterns that legitimize or normalize violence, the results

suggest that such language may be present across ideological texts more broadly. Radical political discourse may therefore share similar rhetorical structures regardless of whether it ultimately culminates in violent action.

One interpretation of this pattern is that linguistic indicators of harm justification may reflect ideological radicalization more generally rather than violence-producing ideologies specifically. The presence of such rhetoric may represent an early stage of moral framing in which political conflicts are interpreted through narratives of victimization and moral grievance. Whether such narratives translate into violent action may depend on additional psychological, cognitive, or situational factors that extend beyond linguistic framing alone.

Importantly, the present analysis represents only an initial component of the broader research design motivating this project. The theoretical framework underlying the study also proposes that integrative complexity, particularly levels of differentiation and integration in reasoning, may play a key role in determining whether ideological beliefs translate into violent action. Previous research in political psychology has demonstrated that integrative complexity can predict major political events, including diplomatic conflict and war escalation. However, its application to the study of lone-actor political violence remains relatively underexplored.

Future analyses incorporating automated integrative complexity (AutoIC) scores will allow for direct testing of the remaining hypotheses of this project. Specifically, the study predicts that lower levels of integrative complexity will be associated with a higher likelihood that a manifesto corresponds with political violence. Additionally, longitudinal analyses of texts produced by the same political actors may reveal whether declining levels of integrative complexity precede increasing justification of harm and eventual violent action.

Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the present findings. The primary limitation concerns the availability of political manifestos. Prior research examining linguistic markers in extremist manifestos has relied on relatively small corpora. For example, studies in this area often analyze sets of six to fifteen manifestos due to the limited availability of such documents, restrictions on access to extremist materials, and the time-intensive nature of manual coding procedures (Capelos et al., 2025; Ebner et al., 2024, 2025). The present study addresses some of these practical limitations by automating both linguistic prevalence analysis and integrative complexity measurement using computational tools in R. Nevertheless, the accessibility of relevant texts remains a constraint on corpus size.

To increase statistical power and broaden the scope of analysis, the present study therefore includes not only terrorist manifestos but also ideological writings that contributed to the development of political platforms. For instance, texts such as *The Manifesto of the Communist Party* — which has been included in prior linguistic studies of political manifestos — are analyzed alongside writings such as Vladimir Lenin's *What Is to Be Done?*, which has not typically been included in this literature. Expanding the dataset to include ideological platform writings allows for the examination of rhetorical patterns across a wider range of political texts while also enabling longitudinal analysis of authors whose writings span multiple time periods.

However, this strategy also introduces conceptual complexity. Political platform writings may differ from terrorist manifestos in important ways, including their intended audience, rhetorical purpose, and historical context. As a result, the linguistic markers observed in such texts may reflect broader ideological discourse rather than mechanisms uniquely associated with political violence.

A second limitation concerns the dictionary-based linguistic approach used in the present analysis. Although dictionary methods provide transparency and replicability, they

inevitably simplify the semantic richness of political rhetoric. Certain forms of moral justification may therefore occur in ways that are not captured by the specific lexical indicators included in the marker dictionary.

Finally, the current analysis does not yet incorporate the integrative complexity measures that constitute a central component of the overall research design. As a result, the findings presented here should be interpreted as preliminary. The analyses primarily demonstrate the feasibility of the linguistic scoring pipeline and provide an initial exploration of how harm-related rhetorical patterns vary across manifesto categories.

Future Directions

Future research can extend the present work in several important ways. Most immediately, incorporating automated integrative complexity measures will allow for direct testing of whether lower levels of cognitive complexity predict the emergence of political violence. Integrative complexity has demonstrated substantial predictive power in analyses of diplomatic communication and political leadership rhetoric. Applying this approach to the study of political manifestos may therefore provide new insights into the cognitive processes that precede ideological violence.

Second, the inclusion of longitudinal textual data offers an opportunity to examine whether changes in linguistic framing and cognitive complexity occur prior to violent action. Many extremist manifestos studied in prior literature are released immediately before or after acts of violence, limiting their usefulness as predictive tools. In contrast, ideological writings and political platform texts often precede violent acts by substantial periods of time. If measurable linguistic or cognitive markers within such texts reliably predict later violence, they could provide valuable signals for identifying escalating radicalization processes.

Third, future work could integrate dictionary-based linguistic analysis with more flexible natural language processing techniques. Methods such as semantic embedding

models or topic modeling may allow researchers to identify broader patterns of moral and ideological rhetoric that extend beyond predefined lexical indicators.

More broadly, integrating linguistic analysis with theoretical frameworks from moral psychology may provide a richer understanding of the cognitive processes underlying political violence. If political grievances are frequently framed through dyadic narratives of harm and victimization, examining how these narratives interact with cognitive structures such as integrative complexity may offer important insight into the psychological pathways through which ideological beliefs develop into violent political action.

Taken together, the present findings represent an initial empirical test of the first hypothesis of this project: that linguistic indicators of harm justification correspond with a higher likelihood of political violence. The elevated prevalence of dyadic harm language in ideologically extreme and violent manifestos provides preliminary support for the claim that moralized narratives of harm and victimization may characterize increasingly radical political discourse. However, the remaining hypotheses — specifically that lower levels of integrative complexity predict political violence and that declining integrative complexity over time precedes increasing justification of harm — remain to be tested once automated integrative complexity measures are incorporated into the dataset. The present analysis therefore serves as a preliminary stage in a broader research program aimed at integrating linguistic indicators of moral reasoning with cognitive measures of ideological complexity in order to better understand the psychological precursors of political violence.

Data analysis

I used R (Version 4.5.2; R Core Team, 2025) and the R-packages *}dplyr* [@}R-dplyr], *forcats* (Version 1.0.1; Wickham, 2025a), *ggplot2* (Version 4.0.2; Wickham, 2016), *here* (Version 1.0.2; Müller, 2025), *janitor* (Version 2.2.1; Firke, 2024), *papaja* (Version 0.1.4; Aust & Barth, 2025), *purrr* (Version 1.2.1; Wickham & Henry, 2026), *readr* (Version 2.1.6; Wickham, Hester, & Bryan, 2025), *readxl* (Version 1.4.5; Wickham & Bryan, 2025), *stringr*

(Version 1.6.0; Wickham, 2025b), *tidyr* (Version 1.3.2; Wickham, Vaughan, & Girlich, 2025), and *tinylabels* (Version 0.2.5; Barth, 2025) for all analyses. The raw manifesto texts extracted from PDF files are not stored in a tidy format because each document appears as a single character string containing many paragraphs and potential marker occurrences. In tidy data, each variable should occupy a column and each observational unit should occupy a row. For the present analysis, the relevant observational unit is a segment of text within a document. The text-processing pipeline therefore converts each document into paragraph-level segments and then expands these segments so that each row represents a document–segment–marker observation. This structure allows marker counts and prevalence rates to be computed using grouped operations and joined with the marker dictionary metadata.

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Appendix A

Table 7

Descriptive statistics for grouped linguistic indicators of harm justification.

Marker Group	Documents	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Hopelessness	251	4.50	4.19	0.00	26.32
Role Model Status	251	0.57	0.84	0.00	5.02
Justification For Violence	251	0.30	0.71	0.00	7.58
Martyrdom Narrative	251	0.16	0.40	0.00	2.26
Dyadic Harm	251	0.10	0.24	0.00	2.44
Violent Reference	251	0.09	0.46	0.00	3.92

Note. Prevalence values represent marker occurrences per 1,000 words. Marker groups aggregate multiple lexical indicators defined in the study's marker dictionary. Document counts indicate the number of manifestos contributing observations to each group.

Appendix B

Table 8

Model fit statistics for regressions predicting grouped marker prevalence from manifesto category.

Outcome	R2	Adj. R2	F	p
Dyadic Harm	0.17	0.10	2.41	0.111
Justification	0.13	0.06	1.80	0.187
Martyrdom	0.20	0.13	2.96	0.071
Hopelessness	0.18	0.12	2.68	0.089

Note. R2 = coefficient of determination; Adj. R2 = adjusted coefficient of determination.